

When the Ideas Shifted but the Movement Endured: William Whipper and Black Temperance in Antebellum Philadelphia

By Michael Clemmons | Published February 1, 2026

Introduction

In the 1830s, Black Philadelphians were building something new beyond churches and beneficial societies. Black-led organizations formed to confront destructive forces including enslavement, poverty, violence, and addiction. Alcohol abuse emerged as one of the most urgent struggles, understood not as a private moral choice but as a collective survival strategy tied to emancipation, political power, and Black civilization's future.

Black temperance societies organized parades, built halls, founded schools, and convened conventions, arguing that addiction functioned as internal enslavement capable of undoing freedom from within. Black newspapers became sites of vigorous debate about public philosophy, with questions about morality, race, discipline, and strategy determining Black public life's future.

At the center of one of the most consequential debates was William Whipper, whose clash with newspaper editor Samuel Cornish played out in *The Colored American* and *The National Reformer*. This article revisits those competing ideas to rehabilitate our understanding of Whipper, his arguments, the movement they inspired, and what that conflict reveals about Black public life's birth in the United States.

Who Was William Whipper?

William Whipper was born free on February 22, 1804, in Little Britain, Lancaster County, Pennsylvania, raised with two brothers and two sisters. Though he had no formal education record, he was well-read and knowledgeable.

At age 24, he moved to Philadelphia and worked as a steam scourer cleaning clothes while living at 32 N. 6th Street. Early in 1835, he opened a free labor and temperance grocery store "next door to Bethel church" that also sold anti-slavery pamphlets and books.

Shortly after arriving, he demonstrated his intellect through association with one of America's first Black literary societies, the Colored Reading Society in Philadelphia for Mental Improvement.

William Whipper became known for his philosophy of moral reform, arguing that Black temperance and moral influence would persuade white acknowledgment of Black humanity and even end enslavement.

A Life Dedicated to Freedom Seekers

Despite his controversial ideas, Whipper's actions demonstrated unequivocal dedication to his people's freedom.

After the 1834 Colored Convention in New York, Whipper relocated from Philadelphia to Columbia, Pennsylvania. Historians believe Stephen Smith, a community leader and successful Black lumberyard owner, influenced this move by offering him a job opportunity at the convention. Whipper gave up his store and relocated within months.

Together, Whipper and Smith operated an Underground Railroad system that freed hundreds using actual trains they owned—the "above ground" underground railroad. Columbia's role as a transportation hub where bridge, rail, canal, river, and turnpike met made it strategically significant along the Susquehanna River.

They later owned stock in the train line and the bridge over the Susquehanna River, operating lumberyards at both Columbia and Philadelphia. The Philadelphia lumberyard was at Broad and Noble, directly across from the current Philadelphia School District Building—likely where people hidden in their train cars escaped into new lives.

Whipper spent decades actively helping people escape enslavement. His Columbia house stood at the bridge's end over the Susquehanna River. People escaping enslavement arrived by boat or foot, crossed the bridge, and reached Whipper's house for help continuing to freedom.

He wrote to William Still after the Civil War: "My house was at the end of the bridge and as I kept the station, I was frequently called up in the night to take charge of the passengers. On their arrival, they were generally penniless and hungry. I have received hundreds in that condition, fed and sheltered from one to 17 at one time in a single night."

On April 6, 1839, Whipper sent a letter to Jacob C. White, a prominent Black business owner and abolitionist: "I send to your Society (vigilance) a man, & woman, the latter is free, the former is in a very perilous situation having seen his Master this afternoon. You will endeavor to render them the usual facilities."

These records complicate the idea of Whipper as detached from struggle or insulated from risk.

His Ideas Challenged

Much of Whipper's controversial reputation stems from two closely related ideas that became shorthand for his politics.

Intemperance as an Evil Equal to Enslavement

Whipper's moral reform argument focused on intemperance (alcohol addiction) as a force structurally equivalent to slavery.

In his January 8, 1834 Presidential Address to the Colored Temperance Society of Philadelphia, Whipper argued that slavery and intemperance are "concomitant," mutually reinforcing systems of domination. While slavery destroys the humanity and civilization of both enslaver and enslaved, intemperance becomes a new, more powerful master—a demon "more ferocious in his character and despotic in the cruelty of his inflictions," whose power is made more dangerous because "those whom he oppresses most, love him best."

In this framing, the formerly enslaved person who gains freedom only to lose it to drink has not escaped domination but simply changed masters. Liquor threatened not only individual well-being but Black institutions' survival. He warned that "uncontrollable liberty," unchecked freedom to drink, would "destroy our institutions and overthrow the foundations of government."

Whipper argued that the way out of this new enslavement is a whole people becoming sober. Three hundred thousand temperate free Black people would create a moral force, changing white public opinion sufficiently to "disperse slavery from the land." He argued intemperance prevented Black people from occupying "the highest situation in the order of intellectual beings," and only through moral purity could "our sable hue be changed from a badge of degradation to a badge of honor."

For him, alcohol control required orchestration by government—specifically moral governance in Black institutions like churches and beneficial societies. He also suggested a new type of organization would help usher in these changes.

However, this argument carried serious consequences. By claiming universal Black temperance would create a "moral force" capable of dispersing slavery, Whipper implicitly placed responsibility for emancipation on Black behavior. Even when unintended as blame, this language created gates to humanity, suggesting freedom and equality depended on moral qualification. This explains his hardened reputation for elitism.

Rejecting Racial Categorization as a Basis for Rights

Running alongside his temperance argument was Whipper's rejection of race as an identity signifier.

Whipper attended the first six Colored Conventions, and his ideas gained traction. At the 1835 Convention, he (seconded by Robert Purvis) made this motion: "to abandon the use of the word 'colored' and 'Africans', when either speaking or writing concerning themselves: and especially to remove the title of African from their institutions, the marbles of churches, etc."

To many contemporaries and later readers, this sounded like attempted erasure, assimilation, or passing.

Whipper framed this not as rejecting Black people but as rejecting racial categorization's political power. He believed racial labels hardened prejudice and locked Black Americans into permanent defensive posture.

In the same period and later in *The National Reformer*, Whipper insisted rights should not flow from color, identity, or racial distinction. He wrote: "For ourselves we solicit neither favor nor patronage on the ground of complexional merit. We are unable to discover why the different shades of the human form should inculcate in us feelings of glory or shame."

His proposal to abandon racial naming at the 1835 Convention grew directly from these beliefs. This position was explosive—sounding like erasure, assimilation, or distancing from Black identity altogether. In practice, it also underestimated how deeply race structured law, violence, and political economy. Rejecting racial categorization did not prevent racialized punishment, as racialized mob violence in 1838 and 1842 would soon clarify.

Why These Two Arguments Made Him a Target

After the 1835 Convention, Whipper founded the American Moral Reform Society (AMRS), emphasizing temperance, education, and self-discipline, challenging members to consider how individual behavior affected collective society.

To bolster his movement, Whipper established the AMRS newspaper *The National Reformer* in September 1838, offering a direct line to the public for advocating AMRS principles. For the next year, it voiced those believing discipline, education, and communal virtue would pave the road to social transformation. His partner Stephen Smith was the Columbia agent.

His 1834 and 1835 ideas now had a growing platform in the AMRS. His temperance argument framed freedom as something losable from within, and his language often dehumanized the very people he sought to protect. His rejection of racial categorization challenged emerging Black solidarity politics at a moment when shared racial identity was becoming a survival tool.

Both arguments assumed that moral force could overcome structural power.

Debate in the Newspapers

Samuel Cornish, the influential *Colored American* newspaper editor, openly critiqued Whipper's philosophies. Historian Van

Gosse suggests Cornish used "Colored" in the newspaper name as open revolt against AMRS contention that racially based names like "African" or "Black" should not be used.

Cornish spent significant adult time at 7th and Bainbridge at First African Presbyterian Church in Philadelphia, making him familiar with most Philadelphia leadership players. Cornish left Philadelphia in 1824 after First African Presbyterian's founding pastor John Gloucester's death, which caused a congregation split with some favoring Cornish as next pastor instead of Gloucester's son Jeremiah. This eventually resulted in Cornish removing himself and moving to New York where he founded *The Colored American*.

Though Cornish had endorsed Whipper's ideas at the 1834 Convention, by 1837 he wrote somewhat respectfully but critically in *The Colored American* of Purvis, Whipper, and their philosophy as delineated at the annual meeting:

"We found a Purvis, a Whipper, and others, (of whose Christian benevolence and cultivated intellect, we have so many and such strong evidences,) vague, wild, indefinite, and confused in their views."

He even called for the President, James Forten, to resign, contending the AMRS should focus on more practical Black benefit rather than promoting moral reform for all American society.

He wrote: "the Society [AMRS] will never do any good, unless it be re-organized and adopt some definite objects of benevolence and definite measures of action."

He continued critiquing the group's emphasis on complexional philosophy and naming over practice: "It is merit, and not complexion, virtue and not name, that makes the man or magnifies the nation"

Whipper willingly engaged philosophically by responding to Cornish with a letter penned September 18, 1837, accepting Cornish's invitation to discuss (not debate), stating his case using American Anti-Slavery Society principles and the Bible.

Cornish's response printed in *The Colored American* on February 10, 1838, immediately after Whipper's letter, stated: "Brother Whipper is a good philanthropist IN PRACTICE; efficient and constant in effort, but in theory he has not learned his A-B-C's- he is as visionary as the wind."

Their discussion was sometimes biting, but mixed with healthy respect, recognition of common goals, and acknowledged as theoretical.

While Cornish respected Whipper's abolitionist work, he objected to the AMRS's emphasis on Black morality leading an American values revolution. He felt Black people's "object" should be Black people—there was enough work there.

He wrote: "We think it TOO MUCH for brother Whipper to carry the whole nation upon his shoulders, in pioneering the improvement of our colored citizens."

Cornish's challenges opened the way for other Black leaders to criticize the AMRS and for a competing organization, the Association for Moral and Mental Improvement (AMMI), to form.

Transformation and the Last Issue

In October 1838, Pennsylvania ratified a new state constitution removing Black men's voting rights. This devastating blow did not immediately discourage Whipper from emphasizing moral reform and colorblindness philosophy.

However, change is inevitable.

By 1839, Whipper's life had shifted profoundly. He had married, started a family, and fatherhood's responsibilities began shaping his outlook. Simultaneously, his work with Stephen Smith in the lumberyard progressed, bringing new demands and opportunities. Time and energy once dedicated to reform and publishing were redirected by his wife, child, and burgeoning career needs.

A Change in Philosophy

In the last *National Reformer* issue (December 1839) as his following declined, Whipper changed his ideas completely in an extended essay, asking forgiveness for his errors.

This reversal must be understood in context. In 1838, the Black community, alongside white allies in the Pennsylvania Abolition Society, undertook extraordinary efforts to prove moral worth and civic responsibility defending the Black vote. A detailed census documented homeownership, mutual aid, stable churches and schools, and hundreds of Black-owned Philadelphia businesses. Despite this evidence of practical citizenship, white Pennsylvanians still chose to disenfranchise Black people.

This approach—providing proof of worth through economic and social signifiers—echoed Whipper's moral reform beliefs. It must have been quite shocking and clarifying when despite this worthiness evidence, white Pennsylvanians still disenfranchised Black people.

By 1839, he wrote: "We, too, have been allured by false idioms. We have been advocates of the doctrine that we must be 'elevated' before we could expect to enjoy the privileges of American citizenship. We now utterly discard it, and ask pardon for

our former errors."

This testified to Whipper's ability to observe reality, listen to reasoned arguments, and critically examine his own philosophies.

Whipper's Columbia business facilitated his transition from theory and philosophy to business, abolition, and family life practicalities. This is not to say he abandoned his intellect. He continued corresponding with thought leaders for many years, but recognized how steady and lucrative income could impact himself, his family, and those liberating themselves from bondage.

Very few Black men could "have freely given one thousand dollars," "borrowed \$1400 on [their] own individual account," or "from 1847 to 1860, contributed...one thousand dollars annually" to freedom's cause as Whipper did. He put his money where his mouth was.

After the Civil War, he bought the Lombard Street house next door to Stephen Smith's house. Both houses still exist and were used as Underground Railroad stops.

Moral Reform After Whipper

Although Whipper focused on Underground Railroad support after the 1830s, Black temperance reform took on new life.

In Philadelphia, leaders including James Forten Jr. and James J.G. Bias continued temperance and improvement work through the American Moral and Mental Improvement Association. The AMMI held a convention in June 1838 at Union Baptist church on Little Pine (now Addison between 6th and 7th). In 1843, Black leaders convened a temperance convention drawing directly from AMRS and AMMI foundations.

Whipper's legacy is that moral reform did not fail entirely when he moved away from leading these ideas—rather it adapted. AMMI focused less on shifting white public opinion and more on temperance's role in undergirding stable Black community.

The 1838 AMMI conference acted as a hub bringing churches and beneficial societies together around community issues including practical needs like school children's clothing and Black community statistics collection.

The Attack on the Temperance Parade and Temperance Hall Destroyed

The limits of Black moral propriety facilitating growing white acceptance became painfully visible in 1842 when the ultimate morality symbols—a sobriety celebration parade and an education and community uplift hall—were attacked by white mobs.

The Temperance movement enjoyed growing 1840s numbers. By 1843, seven Black temperance groups existed in Philadelphia. Dr. James J.G. Bias presided over the largest—the Moyamensing Benevolent Temperance Society claiming 1100 members in 1843.

In 1841, a temperance-dedicated hall opened at 8th and Bedford (now 8th and Kater).

Bias, notably a Philadelphia agent for Cornish's *Colored American*, may have worked full-time at this site. In 1842, he moved from 2 Acorn Alley to 8th and Bedford, the Temperance Hall corner, possibly responding to growing temperance responsibilities.

Abolitionist Henry Clarke Wright described the "Temperance Hall" on Bedford Street as "being in the midst of brothels, grog-shops, gambling hells, kept by whites and blacks -mainly whites." Despite the environment, the small brick hall had successfully become "a comfortable little place in which to gather" with an attached sabbath school where weekly meetings were held.

This hall was attacked during the Lombard Street attack and then torn down by Moyamensing white magistrates, who complained of its anti-slavery ties and that its existence would lead to additional violence. In their press write-up, they complained about anti-slavery documents buried in the building cornerstone. While appearing gracious and patrician, they instead revealed their anti-Black leanings. As government officials, they then used their influence to tear down a perfectly good hall and school.

Black leaders went to press with their reading: that Temperance Hall was torn down because of the Temperance movement's success and its deleterious effect on liquor den profits. In 1842, Dr. James Bias estimated that 450 Moyamensing rum sellers experienced 90% reduction in average daily receipts (from \$5 to \$.50) due to the movement's influence.

This episode's biased nature did not escape public notice. Temperance Hall was noted in the famous satirical 1842 political cartoon "View of the City of Brotherly Love."

Temperance has been the hidden player in much Black Philadelphia history.

For example, what we now call the Lombard Street Riot was an attack on a temperance parade of over 1000 Black men, women, and children.

It was this temperance parade that was attacked by white mobs, starting two days of wanton racialized violence and destruction.

Despite mob violence, in 1843 AMRS also established the "Moral Reform Retreat"—a Black women AMRS leaders Amy 'Hetty'

Reckless and Hetty Burr shelter with intentions to rehabilitate Black women involved in sex work. The Retreat had an attached school. Notably, William Still attended adult education classes at this school when first moving to Philadelphia in the 1840s. Located at 7th and Lombard, it additionally served as an Underground Railroad safe house.

William Whipper's Legacy

William Whipper's story involves conventions and transitions between cities, philosophies, and personal and political elements. His journey from reformer and editor to family man and entrepreneur exemplifies the constant negotiation between ideals and reality defining nineteenth-century Black activism.

His nephew, William J. Whipper, who grew up in the Philadelphia region, later emerged as an important Reconstruction leader in Beaufort, South Carolina. Ideas about civil rights, strategy, and organizing likely circulated through family and business networks, relaying Black Metropolis North experience and lessons to the Reconstruction South.

This influence manifested when Whipper's niece Francis stood up for her civil rights in 1867, refusing to give up her seat on South Carolina public transit.

Francis's son Leigh (Whipper's grand nephew) had a successful Hollywood acting career and was one of the Negro Actors Guild of America's founders.

The debates between Whipper and Cornish, preserved in their newspapers, remain African American intellectual history touchstones. Whipper's change of heart, recorded in his paper's final issue, underscores that even the firmest visionaries are reshaped by life's transitions—love, family, and historical rupture.

Ultimately, William Whipper and the American Moral Reform Society's story is not merely moral philosophy chronicle. It is a meditation on enduring balance between hope and circumstance, theory and practice, a lesson as relevant now as it was in the 1830s.

Images

- William Whipper, c. 1845, attributed to William Matthew Prior (1806 - 1873), oil on canvas. Collection of the Fenimore Art Museum — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_10c1e83a93ba4bbd94d7a81be56bcc94~mv2.jpg
- Whipper advertises his store in the April 5, 1834 Liberator. Courtesy Library of Congress — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_161ef5a8510f437292f400019ce23d1d~mv2.png
- Site of William Whipper's Store "Next to Bethel Church" — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_1debb0e938ae4272b84fb86ba5107ad4~mv2.jpg
- Portrait of Stephen Smith, James Stidun, c. 1840 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_bbb1c0b5f9fa4257a8d792cbf634b624~mv2.png
- From our interactive map with the UGRR Routes layer turned on — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_7b8ded430cbb476dbd9be81d85723310~mv2.png
- Reading & Columbia Railroad Stock Certificate — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_e3aac52d9b684488b378e46a9bbdee03~mv2.jpg
- Whipper's House was at the end of this bridge — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_0871715447a74b98b775b8787705f312~mv2.png
- Note from William Whipper to Jacob C. White — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_326159c6a77740ec8a5502df9a0dadfd~mv2.jpg
- AI recreation of the ABOVE GROUND Underground Railroad — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_928238f11d7244c881ba783ffe20cb35~mv2.png
- In this 1872 drawing "King Alcohol" — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_8fe1704634a644be8c4c5523498b383a~mv2.jpg
- Lithograph of William Whipper from William Still's Underground Railroad — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_7061e029fb264670a602e1ef561ab322~mv2.jpg
- National Reformer newspaper masthead — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_2b71c112f56d47aba85f54635ce0ca14~mv2.png
- The Colored American. 10 Feb. 1838, p. 18 (Cornish response) — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_3c30bd4627d44ec7a2013c594b7a4bbf~mv2.png
- The Colored American. 10 Feb. 1838, p. 18 (continued) — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_5dbd4020c53e4bfdbdcd0fae240fd0b8~mv2.png
- Birth note for William and Harriet Whipper — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_1aa9b86442e84471a1a9d9034c1bee08~mv2.jpg
- Whipper, William. "Our Elevation." National Reformer, Dec. 1839 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_d2b5129747c0447a93ad942b415cc1ed~mv2.png
- Smith-Whipper Houses 921-919 Lombard Street — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_23ffc0aeb6d044deae3ebff1c583aec4~mv2.png
- William Whipper historical marker outside of 919 Lombard Street —

- https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_0f5237f4d81e4d73993ad7d401bcbef9~mv2.png
- Moyamensing Temperance Society membership statistics —
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 - James J.G. Bias temperance parade route advertisement —
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 - William J. Whipper — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_1bdd03a5113c4430ad8439e0c5c6aceb~mv2.jpg
 - Dans un Café à Paris (Leigh Whipper) by Lois Mailou Jones —
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